

Leucocarbo atriceps

Imperial shag



Length 27–30 in (68–76 cm)
Weight 5½–7¼ lb (2.5–3.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Circumpolar around Antarctica, S. South America, Falkland Islands



This distinctive, black and white shag, with blue eye-rings, is from the Southern Hemisphere and found mostly on rocky coasts and islands. A highly gregarious bird, it forms dense winter flocks that forage offshore. In summer, it mainly feeds alone. There are several subspecies of the imperial shag, differing slightly in color and markings.

Phalacrocorax harrisi

Flightless cormorant



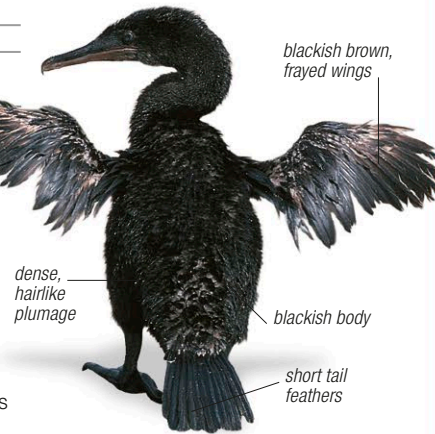
Length 35–39 in (89–100 cm)
Weight 5½–8¼ lb (2.5–4 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable

Location Galapagos Islands (Isabela and Fernandina)



This large cormorant has only the tiniest of wings and long since lost the ability to fly—the absence of terrestrial predators on the Galapagos Islands possibly having made flight unnecessary. It produces very little oil from its preen gland, but the soft, dense body plumage, more like hair than feathers, traps air, which prevents the bird from becoming waterlogged.

The flightless cormorant has a long, strong bill that is useful for flushing octopus and fish from the sea bottom. It breeds in small groups. The male rears the young, continuing to feed them for several months, while the female deserts them to find a new mate.

*Anhinga melanogaster*

Oriental darter



Length 34–38 in (85–97 cm)
Weight 2¼–4½ lb (1–2 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Near threatened

Location Africa (south of Sahara), S. and S.E. Asia, Australia, New Guinea



One of 4 similar species, this cormorant-like bird usually swims with only its head and neck above the waterline, the rest of the body being underwater. It has specially adapted vertebrae in its neck that form a Z-shaped kink, which straightens explosively and enables the darter to spear its prey with its pointed bill. It builds a nest of twigs sometimes as high as 16 ft (5 m) above water, where it lays 3 to 6 eggs.

*Fregata minor*

Great frigatebird



Length 34–41 in (85–105 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Tropical Pacific, Atlantic, and Indian oceans



With their remarkably light bodies and immense, slender wings, great frigatebirds spend their lives gliding effortlessly over the sea, taking food from the surface or from other birds. Their plumage is not waterproof so, when feeding, they dip only their bill into the water, holding the wings up to avoid getting them wet. This

species—one of 5 in the family—has a typically long, hooked black bill and a long, forked tail. The male is black, with a glossy green sheen and long, pale wingbars, and when courting, exhibits a scarlet, balloonlike throat pouch. The female is black and white. The great frigatebird breeds on small, mostly uninhabited islands, forming colonies of up to several thousand pairs.

*Sula nebouxii*

Blue-footed booby



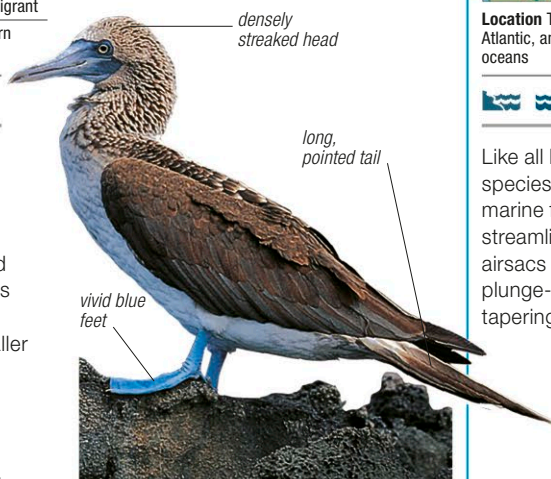
Length 32–34 in (80–85 cm)
Weight 3¼ lb (1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location W. Mexico to N.W. South America, Galapagos Islands

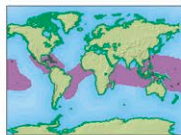


This distinctive seabird, with vivid blue legs and feet, is one of 10 species that make up the gannet and booby family. Like its relatives, it has a cigar-shaped body adapted for plunge-diving, and narrow wings that angle back just before it hits the surface. The male is much smaller and lighter than the female and so especially adept at diving into very shallow, inshore water—even in rock pools. Small groups of birds sometimes dive together for food—

mainly fish such as flying fish, sardines, anchovy, and Pacific mackerel, or squid. The blue-footed is one of the rarer boobies, with a limited distribution. Even its dispersal is relatively restricted; for example, the Galapagos birds move only to nearby Ecuador.

*Sula leucogaster*

Brown booby



Length 25–29 in (64–74 cm)
Weight 1½–3¼ lb (0.7–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Tropical Pacific, Atlantic, and Indian oceans



Like all boobies and gannets, this species is superbly adapted to marine feeding and diving. It has a streamlined, cigar-shaped body, airsacs to cushion the impact of plunge-diving, and a long, tapering bill for grabbing

fish. Making spectacular dives from 100 ft (30 m) or more, it penetrates the water to great depths, bombarding shoals of squid and fish such as mullet. With its long, sturdy wings, the brown booby is also a graceful flier, and the only member of the family in which the male advertises for a mate in flight.

